College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Admissions Watch

More 2025 Matriculations Provide Outlook for 2026

Augsburg's Largst Class in History. The Class of 2029 at Augsburg U. in Minneapolis is the largest in school history, nearly 700 first-year students. Augsburg relies heavily on direct admissions, notifying students with appropriate grades that they qualify for admissions rather than waiting for them to apply.

According to the *Star Tribune*, the liberal arts university "feels like a small-town college in the middle of the state's largest city. [And] Like the six other Lutheran colleges in Minnesota, Augsburg long relied on its connection to the Scandinavian and German heritage of the Upper Midwest to attract students."

But from 2000 to 2014, Augsburg's undergraduate enrollment fell about 30 percent. Then President Paul Pribbenow looked at demographic data and "realized the school's survival depended on its ability to attract more students of color." So it began to recruit more heavily from high schools in Minneapolis and St. Paul and other schools and community colleges dominated by students of color.

"Today, Augsburg has the most diverse student body by far of Minnesota's private colleges; about two out of three Auggie undergraduates are students of color and 55 percent of the entire student body are."

As a result, Augsburg has grown from about 1,900 undergraduate students a decade ago to 2,500 students today. Pribbenow expects the school will reach 3,000 by the end of the decade, surpassing its previous peak years in the late 1990s and early 2000s.

"We educate students to make a living, to make a life and to build community," Pribbenow proudly told the paper.

Bowdoin Admitted 7 Percent. Bowdoin C. in Maine welcomed 515 students to its Class of 2029. They were selected from 14,045 applicants. Bowdoin's acceptance rate was 7 percent. They traveled from 44 states and 50 countries. Seven students joined the class after a gap year and 25 were admitted through the QuestBridge Match process. About 35 percent are students of color. Neither parent of about 18 percent of the new students does not hold a four-year college degree. Some 10 percent of the new class are students with international backgrounds.

The most represented states are California, Colorado, Connecticut, Florida, Maine (with 10 percent), Maryland, Massachusetts, New Jersey, New York, Pennsylvania, Texas and Washington.

Claudia Marroquin, senior vice president and dean of admissions and student aid, said that the admissions office, "traveled the country and the world. We hosted various virtual programs and we took the time to understand our applicants. Seeing students arrive on campus is truly a highlight of this work."

Dartmouth Enrolled All Its New International Students. Despite a summer of concerns about visas, the 15 percent of Dartmouth's Class of 2029 who hail from abroad managed to find their way to the New Hampshire campus and matriculate this fall, Kathryn Bezella, dean of undergraduate admissions, told *The Dartmouth*. "We are in contact with international students and counselors pretty much as we've always been."

But it wasn't easy on the new "Darties." One student told the paper that most international students he knew got visa rejections or had to wait three or four weeks for a decision and that he was scared. Others said they were

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Financial Matters

FAFSA Available Earlier Than Expected. The 2026-27 Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) became available on September 30, the earliest date in recent years. Submitting a FAFSA form is one of the best predictors of whether a high school senior will go to college, according to the National College Attainment Network. NCAN says that students who complete the form are 84 percent more likely to enroll in college directly after high school. Yet only 71 percent of families submitted the form last year, down from 74 percent the previous year.

"Families reported having an easier time completing the (reformed) FAFSA last year," Rick Castellano, a spokesperson for the Sallie Mae, told CNBC. "But 58 percent indicated they still needed assistance. So having a head start can be beneficial, especially for first-time FAFSA filers."

High Schoolers Underestimate Debt Burden. According to Fidelity's 2025 College Savings and Student Debt study, high school students think that they will graduate with $17,000 in loans. But in reality, most graduates with loans will owe double that amount of debt when they leave school.

Worst-Paying College Majors. According to the Federal Reserve Bank of New York, a graduate with an engineering degree can earn up to $80,000 early in his or her career. But many liberal arts and education majors earn closer to $40,000. The median salary of recent graduates in all majors is about $50,000.

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worried and frustrated with the process. But in the end, all the international students in the new class received their visas and are happy to join their classmates.

Delaware's Welcome. The U. of Delaware, founded in 1743 by a group that included signers of the Declaration of Independence and the U.S. Constitution, welcomed 4,100 new students to its Class of 2029. UD enrolls a total of 24,000 students and offers 150 majors and minors.

Grove City Boasts Conservative Values and a Strong Christian Community. Grove City C. in Pennsylvania welcomed 562 new students to its campus for this fall semester, bringing total enrollment to 2,244 students. New students were issued laptop computers, which the college has been providing since the 1990s. Half of the freshman class comes from Pennsylvania, the remainder from 40 other states.

Some 54 percent attended public schools, 25 percent came from Christian schools and 16 percent were homeschooled. The freshman class is 51 percent male. About 40 percent of the new class intends to major in STEM disciplines, 37 percent in liberal arts, 20 percent in business and 3 percent in nursing.

Houston's New Class is Up 12 Percent. The U. of Houston's Class of 2029 is the largest in school history, up 12 percent over last year. The 6,715 new students were selected from more than 48,000 applicants. They are joined by more than 4,500 transfers. Overall, 48,972 students traveled to the nation's fourth-largest city to enroll in the university carrying its name. Applications for UH's Class of 2030 are already up by nearly 20 percent over this time last year.

"As the University of Houston approaches its centennial, we are not just about growing in size," said President Renu Khator, "we are growing in impact. Students are choosing UH because it offers everything they need to succeed: Affordability, opportunity and a nationally competitive academic experience right here in Houston, one of the world's most dynamic cities."

Indiana Enrolls More "Beginner Students." Indiana U. Bloomington enrolled another record-breaking cohort of new students, 10,127 freshmen or "beginner students." Across the IU system, 16,636 beginner students enrolled this fall. Asian American students surpassed Hispanic and international students as the largest non-white ethnic group on the Bloomington campus. This fall, IU Bloomington enrolled 5,163 Asian Americans compared to 4,428 international students, who IU counts as a separate ethnic group. The number of black students and students of color seems to be steadily increasing each year at IUB.

LSU Sets Record. The Class of 2029 that matriculated this fall at Louisiana State U. in Baton Rouge is the largest in school history. Nearly 8,200 first-year students enrolled, 5,000 of them from in-state. The Class of 2029 is also the most accomplished in school history, bringing a high school GPA of 3.85 and including 450 valedictorians. LSU Eunice, LSU Alexandria and LSU Shrevesport all set enrollment records as well.

Marymount Attracted 7,000 Undergrad Apps. Founded in 1950, Marymount U. in Arlington, Virginia, just across the Potomac River from the nation's capital, welcomed its largest new class. The 538 new "Saints" were selected from 7,000 undergraduate applications and hail from 26 states and 17 countries. They posted an average high school GPA of 3.35.

The most popular majors at the Catholic university are nursing, business administration and biology. All new Saints are made to feel at home by taking MU 101, a course helping them adjust to college life with guidance on campus resources, time management, financial literacy, study skills, even on the ethical use of Artificial Intelligence (AI).

Michigan State Welcomed 10,720 New Students. This fall, Michigan State U. in East Lansing, next to the state capital, celebrated its second largest enrollment of 51,838 students. These Spartans come from every corner of Michigan, all 50 states and 139 nations. New undergraduates and transfer students account for 10,720 of that total enrollment.

First-year Spartans were selected from 64,492 applicants, 3.8 percent more than last year's admissions cycle. Nearly 19 percent of the new class hails from out-of-state. Total undergraduate enrollment reached 41,415 students. MSU's Honors College enrolled 609 new members, or 6.5 percent of the class.

Millsaps Grows. Millsaps C. in Jackson, Mississippi, enrolled 172 new freshmen, up from 128 last year, and 36 transfer students. The liberal arts school says it offers "a community that seeks to challenge perspectives, create beauty and effect positive change in the world," and adds that, "Our experiential learning opportunities allow you to apply your knowledge and skills in real-world settings."

Millsaps' enrollment peaked in the 1990s at 1,200 students and gradually declined to last year's 594. But new President Frank Neville told Hawk Central that the school is "just over a year into a rigorous plan to increase enrollment."

Texas Tech First-Year Population Up by 11.7 Percent. Texas Tech U. in Lubbock welcomed 7,600 "first-time-in-college students" to its campus, 11.7 percent more than last year. TT's Class of 2029 is the largest first-year class in school history. That brings Tech's undergraduate population to 33,996, with another 8,276 graduate students.

"Among this year's philanthropic achievements were the creation of 139 new scholarship/financial aid funds, more than $61 million in scholarships and aid to support students and student-athletes, three new endowed academic positions and $43.5 million committed to community initiatives," President Lawrence Schovanec recently noted in his State of the University address.

Vermonters Stays Home. About 80 percent of Vermont college-bound students applied to the U. of Vermont this year, according to Jay

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Harvard's Yield Up Slightly

Harvard U. has been under attack by politicians and in the courts over the past few years. But all the bad publicity doesn't seem to have dimmed the aspirations of the vast majority of Harvard's newly-admitted students. In fact, the *Harvard Crimson* reported that according to the Ivy League's office of admission, "roughly 85 percent of students accepted its offer to enroll in Harvard College's Class of 2029…," a slight increase.

Joy St. John, Harvard C.'s admissions director, reported that roughly 25 to 30 additional students were admitted off of the school's wait list this year because of the uncertainty of the international student situation. *The Crimson* also reported that "roughly 21 percent of the class are first-generation college students, and 24 percent are eligible for federal Pell grants. More than half of the class, 54 percent, will receive institutional grants and 24 percent will pay nothing to attend."

The paper also reported that "the proportion of international freshmen (about 15 percent) was on track to remain roughly steady, despite the Trump administration attacks…." However, that data did not reflect changes that may have occurred over the summer.

Almost 35 percent of the incoming students intend to concentrate on the social sciences, 25 percent in engineering, 26 percent in the natural sciences and almost 12 percent in the humanities. ■

The Counselor's Corner

Enrollment Trends

Common App's Direct Admissions Program. This admissions cycle, the Common App is working with 119 institutions through its Direct Admissions Program. Now in its second year, more than 700,000 students have received admissions offers through the direct admissions program.

During the 2024-25 admissions cycle, about 1.5 million students overall submitted more than 10 million applications through the Common App. During this, its 50th year, 1,100 institutions, including 10 community colleges, are using the Common Application. About 70 percent of them come from families that earn above the national median income.

Duke Reopened Wait List. Duke U. enrolled 50 additional students to its Class of 2029 just two weeks before new students moved into dorms in preparation for this fall's classes. It was the first time in school history that the wait list was reopened. It was officially closed in June after admitting more than 100 students. The wait list reopened after a decision was made to increase the first-year class size from 1,720 to 1,750 students, according to Kathy Phillips, interim dean of undergraduate admissions. Another factor was that only 21 students returned after their gap year. Uncertainty about international students likely played a role as well.

Elite Competition Intensifies. How much harder is it to get into an elite U.S. university? That was the question contemplated by the *Xiang Digest* in Taiwan. "When viewed through the lens of supply and demand, it becomes clear why gaining admission to selective institutions is now more challenging than it was 30, 20, or even 10 years ago."

The *Digest* pointed out that the number of available seats has grown by only a few thousand, but applications to members of the eight Ivy League schools, plus MIT, Duke, Chicago and Stanford U., increased 300 percent from 175,000 in 2002 to 590,000 in 2022.

"This results in a uniquely competitive environment where candidates must showcase not only academic merit but also personal insights and values that resonate with an institution's identity. Consequently, the admissions process has moved towards a holistic assessment, making success more elusive and, paradoxically, subjective."

That means, "It's not just about GPA or standardized test scores, but about demonstrating a clear narrative of purpose, resilience and contribution…. requires applicants to leverage both academic accomplishment and distinctive personal attributes to rise above the numbers game…. Demanding a strategic approach and a keen sense of self, as the hard gets harder."

Hawaii Enrollment Up 2 Percent. Enrollment at the U. of Hawaii's 10 campuses grew by 2 percent this fall to 51,411, the third straight year of increases after years of decline. Freshman enrollment jumped by 4 percent. At the flagship Manoa campus, first-year enrollment soared by 6.2 percent.

International student enrollment rose 1.9 percent, although first-year international enrollment dipped by 6.6 percent. High school students participating in UH's Early Admit program, which allows them to earn college credits, grew by 8.4 percent.

UH President Wendy Hensel said her challenge is to insure balanced growth at campuses across the system. UH just invested $7.4 million in Navigate 360 and EAB Edify to target advising and boost retention. Hensen said the platforms will allow the university to "reach students before they're at a moment of distress."

Iowa Private College Enrollment Up. Private Iowa colleges and universities across the state reported enrollment increases this fall. Many of the schools said that problems with the FAFSA had hurt them last year. But this year, families have a good idea how much aid they can receive.

"It puts a lot of concerns at ease if you know out of the gate that your tuition is going to be covered…. If nothing else it helped us have a conversation with those families," said Steph Peters, vice president for enrollment management at Morningside U.

Last year, Drake U., in Des Moines, launched two initiatives to cover 100 percent of tuition. They have helped increase interest from students in- and out-of-state. First-year enrollment is up 11 percent to 653 students, 33 percent of whom are students of color or historically disadvantaged groups.

Kansas Increased. The Kansas Board of Regents reported a 2.2 percent increase at state schools this fall.

North Carolina System Also Increased. Fall enrollment at the U. of North Carolina System rose 3.4 percent. Fayetteville State U. and North Carolina Central U. in Asheville, which were substantially impacted by hurricane Helene, were the only schools out of 16 state institutions that saw a decline, although their retention rates increased.

"The legislature has been very generous in its funding to the system," David English, UNC Systems vice president for academic affairs, told wfae.org. "This has allowed us to keep costs down to students, which has helped us reset the cost of higher education in North Carolina. It is more affordable today than it was a decade ago."

Northwestern Adds Optional "Dialogues" as Application Supplement. Northwestern U. in Evanston, Illinois, is accepting the Dialogues portfolio for the 2025-26 admissions cycle. Dialogues is part of the educational non-profit Schoolhouse founded by Sal Khan of the Khan Academy.

According to the *Daily Northwestern*, Dialogues offers users opportunities to have "civil discussions about political and cultural issues with peer feedback." Topics include controversial issues such as gun control, immigration, mass incarceration and others hot topics. Students are paired together with opposing viewpoints via Zoom for dialogue, not debate. They are not trying to convince or convert one another, only to gain insight into opposing points of view. They then comment on their sessions. The number of discussions, hours of discussion and topics discussed are compiled into a Dialogues portfolio that students submit to selective colleges.

NU is one of six institutions now accepting the Dialogues portfolio this admissions cycle, including the U. of Chicago, Columbia U., Johns Hopkins U., Colby C. and Washington U.

"We opted to accept Dialogue portfolios as one among many supplemental materials that can help us understand a student's academic and intellectual foundation beyond their high school transcript," Liz Kinsley, NU's dean of undergraduate admission, told the paper. "We see the premise of Dialogues as particularly well aligned with Northwestern's priorities around supporting free expression and engaging across differences." ■

Stanford Retains Legacies

In order to maintain its use of legacy and donor status in admissions, Stanford U. decided to opt out of the Cal Grant financial aid program. A California law that went into effect September 1 prohibits legacy or donor-driven preferences in admissions at any university "that receives, or benefits from, state-funded student financial assistance or that enrolls students who received state-funded student financial assistance," including private institutions such as Stanford.

Stanford, which maintains one of the nation's largest endowments, declared that it will use its own university scholarship funding instead of state financial assistance so that it may admit the students it selects and maintain ties with its alumni and donors. ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Iowa's Integrated Health Sciences. The Iowa Board of Regents approved a new Bachelor of Science in integrated health sciences at Iowa State U., the U. of Iowa and Northern Iowa U. that began this fall. The colleges of agriculture and life sciences, health and human sciences and liberal arts and sciences will contribute to the interdisciplinary major. At the same time, the Board of Regents eliminated doctoral programs in rural, agricultural, technological and environmental history due to low enrollment.

Montclair State U. Launched Four New Online Programs. This fall, Montclair State U. in New Jersey began an online master's program in strategic communication and media, an online bachelor's program in family science and human development, another online bachelor's in economics and an online graduate certificate in supply chain management.

Oregon's Three New Programs. Students at the U. of Oregon will soon be able to earn a B.S. in materials science, a postgraduate degree in school psychology and a brewing innovations minor.

Pepperdine/Japan. Next academic year, Pepperdine U. in Malibu, California will launch its newest academic program in Kyoto, Japan. "In Kyoto, our students will experience a living classroom and be immersed in the traditions, innovations and beauty of Japan, while engaging with world-class faculty and global peers," said provost Jay Brewster. ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

The Home Stretch of Student Recruitment: How colleges are reinventing the post-admissions process, The Chronicle of Higher Education, $199. See https://store.chronicle.com/products/the-home-stretch-of-student-recruitment.

Dream Schools: Finding the College That's Right for You by Jeffery Selingo, Scribner, ISBN-13: 9781668056202, $30. In a September 22 edition of *The New York Times* Guest Essay, "Don't Fall for the Rigged College Game," Selingo wrote that every fall as another admissions season begins, seniors open up scattergrams that show where previous applicants from their school were accepted, denied or wait listed and scanned for their dream colleges. When they see the results, "they get nervous" and "their response is always the same: Apply to more schools. Yet nearly all of the additions are what, in admissions parlance, are called 'reach schools,' rather than schools deeper in the rankings that would be 'match' or 'safety' schools."

"That mind-set makes acceptance to a highly-selective college feel like a game. The rules are set by colleges, and carried out by admissions offices, and are stacked against the vast majority of teenagers. Fewer than a tenth of applicants win that prize of getting into one of the nation's most selective colleges."

Selingo wrote, "But we're missing the bigger picture. The frantic competition that we've made the norm is based on a lie about what makes a college education truly valuable.… [a good 'fit' and learning engagement]…there are hundreds and hundreds of schools where students can get a good education…."

"When you can get parents genuinely to signal to their own kids that they value fit over prestige, it helps break the arms race because parental pressure and opinion shape much of the college search." ■

ADMISSIONS WATCH

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Jacobs, UVM's vice president for enrollment management. Just under 40 percent of them, 221 students, are part of UVM's Promise program, which covers four years of tuition for admitted students whose household income is $100,000 or less.

About 14 percent of the new class is made up of first-generation college students, up from 11 percent last year. And 40 percent of incoming undergraduate students are males, compared to 38 percent last year. The number of students enrolled in both UVM's College of Engineering and Mathematical Sciences and the Grossman School of Business jumped by about 15 percent.

This year's class includes an American Idol contestant, a published fantasy fiction writer, an accomplished rock climber, a model UN Best Delegate from Kyrgyzstan, a concert pianist who has performed at The Lincoln Center, Carnegie Hall and in a number of other nations and a member of the U.S. Ski Team.

Wabash "Rings In" its 193rd Class. Wabash, the all-men's college in Inzdiana, "rang in" 272 new students into its Class of 2029 using the same bell that welcomed its first class of 12 students 193 years ago. They come from 18 states and 15 countries. "No matter what your path through Wabash will be," Scott Brown, dean of students, told them, "all of you have the ability, starting right now, to lead wise and virtuous lives. But you must choose to become men of integrity, men who make a difference in our troubled world… and I promise you that over the next four years, you will receive all the education you need to pursue them."

Wilson Enrollment Jumped 38 Percent in Three Years. Warren Wilson C., 10 miles east of Asheville, N.C., reached an all-time enrollment high of 1,877, a 10 percent increase over last fall and a 38 percent jump in the last three years. New programs in computer science and cybersecurity, veterinary nursing, pre-vet and BSN pre-licensing helped drive the increase. About 94 percent of graduates are employed or pursuing further education.

To make sure students succeed, Wilson restructured its Academic Success Center. Every student now is assigned a Student Success Coach and a Personal Librarian. ■

FINANCIAL MATTERS

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Here's what the Fed listed as the 10 lowest-paying majors: foreign languages, $40,000; general social sciences, $41,000; performing arts, $41,900; anthropology, $42,000; early childhood education, $42,000; family and consumer sciences, $42,000; general education, $42,000; miscellaneous biological sciences, $42,000; social services, $42,000 and theology and religion, $42,000.

According to CNBC, not all degrees mean higher salaries, "especially if you study liberal arts." The statistics are for those 22-27 years old, using 2023 data. ■

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